

Missing: A foldable iPhone?

Foldable phones are bringing life to the smartphone industry, injecting a much-needed dose of excitement and novelty into a market that had been feeling somewhat stale. With major smartphone brands now showcasing their foldable phone collections, all eyes are on the poster boy of the smartphone world – Apple. So, the question on everyone's lips is: Why is Apple not diving headfirst into the foldable phenomenon?

Fresh from the rumour mill, there's talk of Apple working on a foldable device, but here's the twist: it's not a phone; it's a tablet. It seems like Apple is taking baby steps into the foldable market, perhaps testing the waters before making a big splash. Reports suggest that Apple's cautious approach is because they want to get things right, especially in terms of design and materials. They've filed numerous patents related to flexible display-based devices, making it clear that they're keen to join the foldable market. But the clock is ticking, as the Android side of foldable tech is booming, and 2024 promises even more foldable devices. The Android market is buzzing with foldable phones from major players such as Samsung, OnePlus, Google, Motorola, OPPO, and Honor. We're already observing a level of segmentation in the foldable market, with companies like Tecno offering more affordable options (although still priced in the flagship range). It's evident that the foldable phone market is ready to turn a page.

As an iPhone user, I've often wondered if a foldable iPhone would make me flip. For me, the perfect foldable phone would be no more thicker than a regular phone (under 10mm) and has to keep the weight in check as well (under 200 grams). In fact, a foldable iPhone SE would be perfect in my books. A device that's compact and yet delivers a big screen experience when one needs it.

However, the clunky nature of current crop of foldable phones, with their added thickness and weight, coupled with their fragility, is a major turn-off. Not to mention the premium price tag, which can be a



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cause for concern rather than celebration. Then, there's the ever-persistent crease in the middle of the screen, which, though improving with each new version, remains a reminder that perfection is still a work in progress. The protective layer on foldable screens can potentially wear out rather quickly, leaving you wishing you had never unfolded that expensive and unwieldy gadget. Flexible display technology has made great strides, but it's not without its challenges. The fundamental issues related to material science have yet to be fully addressed. The flexible plastic membrane is not as robust as traditional glass, and the hinge mechanism, allowing the phone to fold, presents its own set of problems due to moving parts and a complex design.

But there's hope on the horizon. The smartphone industry has a history of tackling challenges head-on and coming up with innovative solutions. The displays will eventually drop that crease, and the hinge mechanism will be perfected. And soon, the focus is likely to shift from troubleshooting design issues to exploring unique use cases and experiences for foldable devices. Foldable form factors are undoubtedly the future, and there's a flurry of innovation happening behind the scenes to perfect them.

So, will Apple catch-up with the rest and release a nearly perfect foldable device? Or will it have a completely different take on a foldable phone? What's your opinion on the rapidly unfolding frenzy around flip-and-fold phones? **d**



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